

ESSENTIAL

Visitor Visa (TRV) Master Guide

The complete walkthrough - process, dual intent, validity, and FAQs

VERIFY BEFORE YOU APPLY

Fees, forms, and processing times change without notice. This guide reflects publicly documented procedures as commonly published; treat every dollar figure, form number, and timeline here as a starting point, and confirm the current version on the official government site before you submit anything or pay any fee.

What the Visitor Visa (TRV) is - and isn't

A Temporary Resident Visa lets nationals of countries that aren't visa-exempt travel to Canada for tourism, visiting family or friends, or short business activities. It's decided under IRPA/IRPR by an IRCC visa officer. It does not permit taking employment in Canada, and it does not permit enrolling in a study programme longer than the short-course exception permitted for visitors.

The process end to end

Step	What happens
1. Apply online	Complete the application through your IRCC secure account, or on paper (form IMM 5257) if required.
2. Pay fees	Pay the processing fee, plus a separate biometric fee unless exempt.
3. Give biometrics	Attend a Visa Application Centre (VAC) for fingerprints and a photo, unless exempt or reusing recent biometrics.
4. Submit documents	Upload financial and ties-to-home evidence - see the Document Checklist.
5. Decision	Most applications are decided on the written file by an IRCC visa officer, without an interview. Processing times vary significantly by country - check current times on the IRCC website for your application location.
6. Get your visa	If approved, a visa counterfoil is placed in your passport (or, depending on your situation, you may instead be issued an eTA-linked entry status) - check the confirmation you receive for what applies to you.

“Dual intent” - a genuinely Canadian feature

YOU CAN HAVE DUAL INTENT

Unlike some countries where any evidence of wanting to immigrate can count against a temporary visa application, Canadian law explicitly recognises “dual intent” (IRPA section 22(2)): you're allowed to intend to apply for permanent residence in the future while still qualifying for a temporary visa now. What the officer needs to be satisfied of is narrower - that you would leave Canada by the end of your authorized stay if your temporary status isn't extended or converted. Mentioning a long-term interest in Canada doesn't automatically doom a visitor application the way it might elsewhere, provided you can still show you'd comply with your temporary status.

Visa validity vs. length of stay

A TRV itself is often issued as multiple-entry, valid for up to 10 years or until your passport expires, whichever is sooner - this is the visa's validity, not a guarantee of how long you can stay on each visit. A border services officer decides your actual authorized stay on arrival (commonly up to 6 months, but it can be shorter, and is recorded in your passport or, more often now, in your electronic travel record - always check the date given at the border rather than assuming 6 months by default).

Extending your stay: the Visitor Record

If you want to stay longer than your authorized period, you must apply for an extension (a Visitor Record) before your current status expires - simply leaving and re-entering isn't a substitute, and overstaying without an approved extension can affect future applications.

Frequently asked questions

Can I work on a Visitor Visa?

No - a TRV doesn't permit employment. A small set of specific business activities (meetings, negotiations, conferences) that don't amount to entering the Canadian labour market are permitted; anything resembling actual work needs a work permit instead.

Do I need travel/medical insurance?

It's not a strict visa requirement, but Canada has no free public healthcare access for visitors, so comprehensive travel medical insurance is strongly advisable.

What if I'm refused?

See the Refusal Decision Guide (Premium tier) for how reapplication and judicial review work.